

SKILLING STRATEGY



THE SKILL INDIA MISSION, LAUNCHED IN 2014, AIMS TO MAKE CANDIDATES EMPLOYABLE



OVER 60 MILLION INDIANS HAVE BEEN TRAINED THROUGH SCHEMES LIKE PM KAUSHAL VIKAS YOJANA



COURSES ARE BASED ON INDUSTRY INPUTS AND ALSO COVER EMERGING FIELDS LIKE AI, ROBOTICS, AND IoT



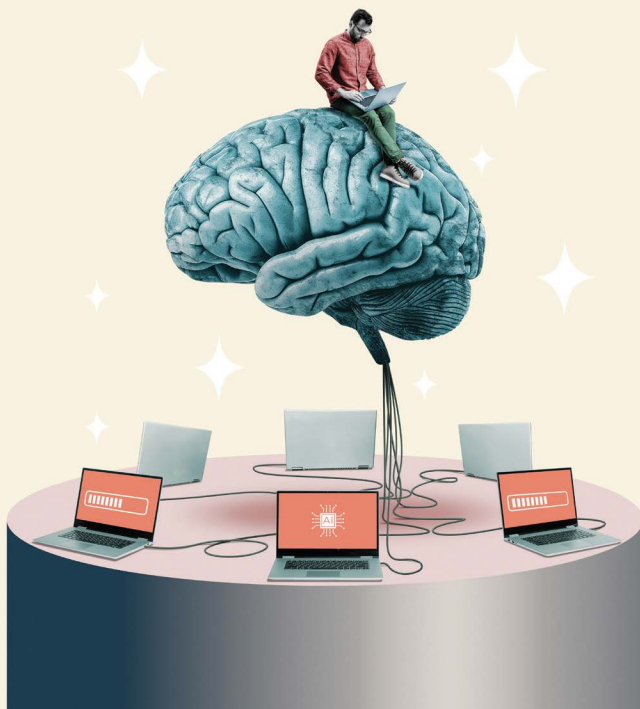
CONCERNS OVER SHORT-DURATION TRAINING, INDUSTRY DISCONNECT, PLACEMENTS AND LOW SALARIES



THERE HAS ALSO BEEN A VACUUM AT THE NATIONAL SKILL DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION AFTER ITS CEO'S EXIT IN MAY 2025



INDIA NEEDS TO UP ITS SKILLING GAME TO TAP THE DEMOGRAPHIC DIVIDEND



ship PMKVY, which provides skill certification and training in industry-relevant courses through various modules, including short term training, special projects and recognition of prior learning.

Tata group veteran Jayant Krishna, who is currently non-resident senior fellow with the Chair on India and Emerging Asia Economics at the Washington D.C.-based Center for Strategic and International Studies, and former CEO, ED & COO of NSDC, says while earlier, skilling was driven by polytechnics and ITIs, government and private sector initiatives are working on a much larger scale. "Prior to that, the country was skilling about one million people annually, largely through polytechnics and ITIs."

TIME FOR A RESET

However, the Skill India Mission has been in the eye of a storm in recent months because of the sudden removal of NSDC CEO Ved Mani Tiwari, effective May 16, with a public notice by the agency attributing this to a decision of its Board of Directors. It did not provide a reason for the decision.

The NSDC did not respond to a questionnaire sent by *Business Today*. Sources close to the development point to a difference of opinion on how skilling initiatives should be run, specifically with greater emphasis on tech and AI. In the ensuing months, the NSDC board has undergone a restructuring, but remains without a CEO, which has raised concerns about its functioning. The board includes government officials as well as representatives from industry chambers.

Even beyond this immediate problem, there are a host of challenges, the solutions for which may not always be easy.

Santosh Mehrotra, a labour economist and retired professor at the Jawaharlal Nehru University, says, "They are churning out short-term trainees to meet targets. But short-term training of three months under the PMKVY is not sufficient to impart proper skills." As a result, candidates get low-paying jobs, often in the informal sector, which they end up leaving soon thereafter. "This is evident in low placement rates under the scheme," he says.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Labour, Textiles and Skill Development, in a report in March, raised other issues, too. It noted that while skill development is crucial, its impact remains limited unless accompanied by employment genera-